2.3 Women's Roles in the Revolution

If colonial women could time travel to the present day, many would probably be surprised to see American women working alongside men in most settings. But some would feel right at home.

MAIN IDEA Even though they could not officially serve in the army, women played many key roles in the American Revolution.

BEFORE THE REVOLUTION

Colonial women had long stood with men against the British. For instance, do you remember that before the American Revolution, the Daughters of Liberty helped organize a boycott of British goods? **Mercy Otis Warren** was an outspoken supporter of these boycotts. She became active in colonial politics through one of the committees of correspondence and went on to become a notable historian of the Revolutionary era.

John Adams's wife, **Abigail Adams**, also played a vital role from the earliest days of the Revolution. Along with Mercy Otis Warren and the governor's wife, Hannah Winthrop, Adams was appointed by the Massachusetts Colony General Court to question and report on local women suspected of being Loyalists. Both Adams and Warren were sharp thinkers and skilled writers who freely voiced their ideas about liberty, independence, women's rights, and a new government.

DURING THE REVOLUTION

As often happens in wartime, women took over many duties at home traditionally performed by men. Women ran farms, shops, and businesses. They also supported soldiers who passed through their communities, giving them housing and food. Some women took more direct action. They traveled with the troops, working as nurses, cooking men's meals, and washing their clothes.

You may be surprised to learn that some women excelled at **espionage**, or spying. This was due in great part to the fact that men tended to underestimate them. Many of these spies worked as maids or cooks for British officers and so had access to valuable information. Some women even took part in combat, disguising themselves as men or at times simply stepping into battle. They risked not only the dangers of combat but also jail if it were discovered that they were women.

In 1777, **Sybil Ludington** rode more than 40 miles in a single night to warn forces commanded by her father of a British attack in Connecticut. The British planned to destroy American supplies there. She also warned the people along the way.

When women did not have a defined role in the war, they were resourceful in finding ways to help—some of which could be very risky. Abigail Adams's appeal to her husband still did not bring equal rights to American women. But colonial women had shown their ability to participate in the building of a new nation.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did women contribute to the success of the American Revolution?
2. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Which woman named in this lesson do you think contributed most to the American Revolution? Use evidence from the text to explain and support your opinion.
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** In what way do Abigail Adams's comments to her husband reflect ideas in the Declaration of Independence?

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Remember the Ladies

The four women featured on this page—Abigail Adams, Anna Smith Strong, Mary Ludwig Hays McCauly, and Phillis Wheatley—provide examples of women who were every bit as involved and took the same or greater risks in the American Revolution as the men.



Portrait of Abigail Adams by Benjamin Blyth, c. 1766

Abigail Adams wrote the following to her husband, John Adams, affirming that women were as much a force behind the war as men and deserved to be heard.

> "In the new Code of Laws which I suppose it will be necessary for you to make I desire you would **Remember the Ladies** . . . we are determined to foment a Rebellion, and will not hold ourselves bound by any Laws in which we have no voice, or Representation."
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> —Abigail Adams in a letter to John Adams, March 31, 1776

Molly Pitcher at the Cannon's Mouth **postcard, 1909**



Mary Ludwig Hays McCauly carried water to cool off the soldiers and the hot cannon her husband was firing during battles. This earned her the nickname Molly Pitcher. She also worked with her husband to fire the cannon. Other women served in combat during the war. One of them was Margaret Corbin, who is buried and honored with a monument at the United States Military Academy at West Point, New York. The woman in the postcard above represents not just Molly Pitcher but all the brave women who faced combat during the Revolution.

Phillis Wheatley proved the pen could also be a mighty weapon. She was born in Africa, enslaved as a young girl, and sold to a family of Boston Quakers who provided her with a good education. She became a poet who called for freedom for all, praised George Washington, and supported the American Revolution. She was the first African-American poet to have her work published.

Anna Smith Strong was a member of a spy ring on the coast of New York. She used a code based on how she hung out her laundry to let other members of the ring know when a messenger with information was arriving. A black petticoat on her clothesline meant the messenger was coming. The number of handkerchiefs scattered on the line indicated the cove in which he would land.

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